

Planting the Bay — Website Design Brief

Prepared for: Web Designer / Developer **Prepared by:** Stuart Mains **Project:** Fundraising, storytelling & vision-casting website for a Bay Area church-planting initiative **Domains owned:** `plantingthebay.com` and `plantthebay.com`

1. Project Overview

We are launching a church-planting and campus-ministry initiative across the San Francisco Bay Area, beginning **September 1**. The strategy is to plant first in **Berkeley** in partnership with the **SF Bay Fellowship** — building both campus ministry and a local church — and then expand outward into the other regions of the Bay: **San Francisco, the Peninsula, San Jose, the Tri-Valley, and beyond**.

Stuart and Ashley Mains serve as **Lead Evangelist and Planting Coordinators**. In Year 1 we are hiring **two additional staff couples** focused on campus ministry and church planting.

The website has **three jobs**: 1. **Tell the story** of what we're doing in a way that's emotionally compelling and easy to follow. 2. **Cast the vision** for a multi-region Bay Area movement. 3. **Convert** that story and vision into **donations** and **people getting involved**.

The two flows that must feel absolutely **seamless and friction-free** are: **(a) the storytelling** and **(b) giving / getting involved**. Everything else serves those two.

2. Goals & Success Metrics

Fundraising targets (anchor the design around these): - **Year 1: \$1,000,000** - **Year 2: \$2,000,000** - **Year 3: \$2,000,000+** (*rapid expansion to absorb new baptisms and people relocating into the area and the church*)

Primary site goals: - Drive one-time and **recurring** donations. - Recruit **staff couples, volunteers**, and **people willing to relocate** to join the plantings. - Capture **emails** for an ongoing supporter/prayer pipeline. - Communicate momentum and vision to keep donors engaged over a 3-year arc.

Success metrics the build should support measuring: - Donation conversion rate (visit → gift) and recurring-donor signups. - "Get Involved" form submissions by pathway (serve / relocate / join staff). - Email captures. - Mobile vs. desktop conversion (we expect **mobile-dominant** traffic from social).

3. Target Audiences

The site speaks to several audiences at once — design should let each find their path quickly from the homepage:

1. **Donors** — ICOC members, churches, existing networks, and Stuart's social audience. Range from \$25/mo sustainers to major/legacy gifts.
 2. **Potential team members** — staff couples, interns, and families considering relocating to the Bay.
 3. **Volunteers & local supporters** — people who want to serve, host, or pray.
 4. **Curious / seekers** — people drawn in via social media who may attend a pop-up service or get involved.
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4. Tone, Brand & Visual Direction

- **Visually engaging, modern, and editorial** — not a dated "church website." Think clean, confident, contemporary, with strong typography and generous imagery/video.
- **Mobile-first.** The majority of traffic will arrive from social. Every layout, CTA, and form must be designed for thumb-driven mobile use first, then scaled up.
- **Video- and photo-forward.** Real faces, real Bay Area locations. Avoid stock-photo feel.
- **Energetic but trustworthy.** Big vision balanced with the credibility/transparency a donor needs to give confidently.
- **Bay Area sense of place.** The geography is part of the story — bridges, campuses, neighborhoods, the multi-region expansion.

(Designer to develop a logo/wordmark direction, color palette, and type system. A short brand-direction round before full design is recommended.)

5. Sitemap

Primary navigation: 1. **Home** 2. **Our Story** 3. **Our Vision** 4. **Why the Bay** (*the need / the data case*) 5. **Get Involved** 6. **Give**

Secondary / utility (footer or sub-nav): - The Team (Stuart & Ashley + open staff roles) - Updates / Stories (blog) - Prayer - Partners - FAQ - Contact

Persistent global elements: - A **"Give"** button pinned in the nav on every page (and a sticky mobile CTA). - A secondary **"Get Involved"** CTA. - Footer with email signup, social links, 501(c)(3) / giving info, contact.

6. Page-by-Page Requirements

6.1 Home

The front door — must instantly convey *what, where, why, and how to act*. - **Hero:** short, punchy vision statement + a **30-60 second vision video** (or strong hero imagery if video isn't ready at launch). Two clear CTAs: **Give** and **Get Involved**. - **At-a-glance vision strip:** Berkeley first → expand across the Bay (visual/animated). - **Momentum band:** fundraising progress toward the Year 1 goal (thermometer/progress bar); later, a baptism/people counter. - **Brief "why the Bay" teaser** linking to the full page. - **Featured story** + latest updates teaser. - **Email capture.** - Designed so a first-time visitor from Instagram can understand the whole thing in one scroll.

6.2 Our Story

- The narrative of who we are and how this came to be — Stuart & Ashley's calling, the partnership with the SF Bay Fellowship, the heart behind it.
- Long-form but **visually broken up:** photos, pull quotes, short video clips.
- Clear emotional through-line ending in a CTA (give / get involved / subscribe).

6.3 Our Vision

The strategy and the "how." Include the three pillars explicitly: - **Social media outreach** — how we use digital reach to find and engage people across the Bay. - **Pop-up services** around the region — with an **events/RSVP module** so visitors can find and sign up for the next one. - **Campus ministry growth** — the model for building on Bay Area campuses. - **The expansion roadmap:** Berkeley → SF → Peninsula → San Jose → Tri-Valley → beyond. Present this as an **interactive map and/or phased timeline**. - *Asset note:* we have an existing **3D Bay Area flyover** that should be incorporated/repurposed here as the centerpiece.

6.4 Why the Bay (The Need)

- The data-driven case for **why the Bay Area, why now** — including survey data identifying the region as the highest-leverage planting opportunity in North America.
- Stats, maps, and simple infographics. This page exists to build **donor confidence** and justify the scale of the ask.

6.5 Get Involved

The recruiting hub — make the pathways distinct and obvious: - **Join the team / planting staff** — for couples and families considering relocating to plant with us (links to open staff-couple roles). - **Serve / volunteer** — local involvement. - **Pray** — link to the prayer page. - Application/interest **form(s)** segmented by pathway, with clear next steps after submission (confirmation + what happens next).

6.6 Give

The most important conversion page. Must be **dead simple and trustworthy**. - **One-time vs. recurring toggle** — recurring is emphasized. - **Suggested impact tiers** rather than bare numbers, e.g. "\$250/mo helps fund a campus intern" (final tiers/copy TBD). - **Named recurring program** — e.g. "**Founding 100**" / "**Bay Builders**" monthly sustainer program with its own framing and a goal of recruiting a defined number of monthly partners. - **Fund designation** — ability to give to the general initiative or a designated "**Planting the Bay**" fund (we operate a two-fund 501(c)(3) structure). - **Tax-deductibility note** + automated receipts. - **Multiple methods:** card and ACH at minimum; ideally support for **Donor-Advised Funds (DAF), stock, and large/major gifts** (can be "contact us" links rather than full integrations at launch). - "**Where your gift goes**" — a transparent breakdown of the Year 1 budget / use of funds. Major donors will look for this. - Mobile giving must be **2-3 taps to complete**.

7. Additional Pages / Modules (recommended)

- **The Team** — Stuart & Ashley with bios/photos; the two **open staff-couple roles** presented as a recruiting opportunity. People give to people; this page does real fundraising and recruiting work.
- **Updates / Stories (Blog)** — ongoing posts and short videos. Essential for **donor retention** over a 3-year campaign; gives monthly partners a reason to stay engaged.
- **Prayer** — a simple prayer-request submission and/or prayer wall. The on-ramp for people who can't give financially.
- **Partners & Endorsements** — SF Bay Fellowship, ICOC affiliation, partner logos, and a few endorsement quotes for credibility.
- **FAQ** — covering: where the money goes, tax deductibility, what a church plant is, the ICOC connection, how to relocate/join, how to host a pop-up, etc.
- **Contact** — general inquiries, plus press/media.

- **Social hub** — embed Stuart's reels/feed; turn the site into a content destination that leverages the existing ~59K-follower reach.
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8. Key Functionality Requirements

- **Donation platform integration** with: recurring billing, fund designation, automated tax receipts, and a clean mobile checkout. *(Stripe is already available to us; a church/nonprofit giving layer such as Tithe.ly, Givebutter, Donorbox, or Pushpay may be worth scoping on top for recurring + fund management + receipting. Designer/developer to recommend.)*
 - **Fundraising progress meter** that can be updated easily (and ideally pulls live totals).
 - **Events / pop-up service module** with RSVP and locations/map.
 - **Multi-pathway forms** for Get Involved (serve / relocate / staff) feeding a CRM or at minimum email + a clear notification to us.
 - **Email capture** integrated with our email/newsletter tool, with a lead-magnet opt-in (e.g. a devotional or vision PDF).
 - **Blog/CMS** that a non-developer can update.
 - **Interactive expansion map** (incorporating the existing 3D flyover asset).
 - **Social embeds** and easy share-ability of stories/pages.
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9. Technical Requirements

- **Mobile-first, fully responsive**, fast-loading (optimized images/video, lazy loading).
 - **Two domains:** choose **one canonical domain** (recommend `plantingthebay.com`, where the flyover already lives) and **301-redirect** the other (`plantthebay.com`) to it. Both should be secured and pointed correctly.
 - **SEO foundations:** clean metadata, social/Open Graph cards (these pages will be shared heavily on social), sensible URL structure, schema where useful.
 - **Analytics & conversion tracking:** track donations, form submissions, and email captures end-to-end so we can measure the funnel.
 - **Accessibility:** WCAG-conscious (contrast, alt text, keyboard nav).
 - **CMS / editability:** we need to update stories, the progress meter, events, and team info ourselves without a developer.
 - **Performance & security:** SSL, fast hosting, spam protection on forms, PCI-compliant giving.
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10. Content & Assets

We will provide: - Copy for core pages (or drafts to be polished). - Photography and video, including (target) a hero vision video. - The existing **3D Bay Area flyover** asset. - Logos/brand elements (or designer to develop — see §4). - Budget breakdown figures for the "Where your gift goes" section. - Bios and photos for Stuart & Ashley and role descriptions for open staff positions.

We may need help with: brand/visual identity, infographic design (for the data case), and light video editing.

11. Questions for the Designer

- Recommended platform/stack given the mobile-first + CMS + giving + events requirements?
 - Recommended giving solution (and whether to layer on Stripe or use a church-specific tool)?
 - Suggested phasing for an MVP launch ahead of September 1?
 - What do you need from us, and by when, to hit the launch target?
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Two flows must feel effortless above all else: following the story and giving / getting involved. When in doubt, optimize for those.